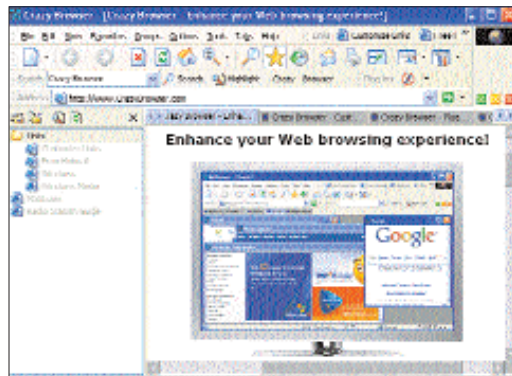


ilarity of its interface means that you need hardly spend any time getting to grips with the software itself.

The Browser

There are only three browsers worth mentioning today—Internet Explorer (IE), Firefox and Opera.

For IE users, there is Crazy Browser, a 500 KB browser that seems to be a heady mix of all three—it uses the IE engine, but also brings in some cool features from the other two, like tabbed browsing,



plug-ins (à la Firefox extensions) and mouse gestures (quite similar to Opera's). It even has its own pop-up blocker and RSS reader.

The same open source community that's responsible for Portable OpenOffice.org and Portable Thunderbird also gives us Portable Firefox, which is just that—a fully functional USB version of the Firefox browser, including support for installing the insanely popular Firefox extensions, but at 17 MB, you're going to be crunched for space.



Unfortunately, Opera hasn't yet released a portable version of their browser, but a few intrepid users have tweaked the existing Opera to make it capable of being run off a USB drive. You can download it from www.opera-usb.com. Remember, this is not an official release by Opera, so if things go wrong, you're on your own.

While Adobe Reader is the *de facto* for reading PDF documents, it's bulky and is a resource hog. Overcoming both these nags is Foxit PDF Reader

The Media Player

Work or play, chances are you can't escape without encountering a sound or video clip that needs viewing. Since we can't guarantee that the PC of the hour has all the codecs necessary for us to open the files, we've decided on VLC Player, which can play nearly any audio and video file in existence, and doesn't require any codecs to be pre-installed on the system. It's a tad costly at nearly 35 MB, though.



Another option is MPUI, a GUI for the popular open source MPlayer. This, too, doesn't need any codecs to be installed on the PC you'll be working on, and it's a lot lighter at 7 MB. In its current stage it's a little buggy, but definitely worth the 28 MB you'll save.

The Image Viewer

IrfanView supports a huge number of image formats, is light on system resources, easy to use, and can even convert images to different formats with some really good compression ratios.



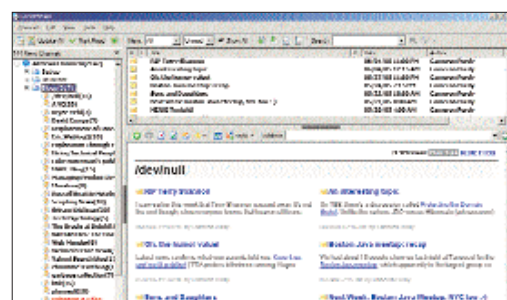
The Newsfeed Reader

You still need to keep in touch with the latest news when you're on the move, and what better way than with a good RSS feed reader? GreatNews is a really good feed reader which even integrates browsing via the IE engine. It also comes pre-loaded with settings for many great sites, including a vital *Dilbert* comic feed.

You can view the feeds in any style you choose—be it simple text or a newspaper-like appearance. And at 3 MB, it's more than you'd hope for.

The PDF Reader

While Adobe Reader is the *de facto* for reading PDF documents, it's bulky and is a resource hog. Overcoming both these nags is Foxit PDF Reader. It occupies only 2 MB of space, and is so light that it even works even on PCs that are a couple of



Getting Your USB Drive To Autorun

On PCs with Windows XP and Service Pack 2, you can bring up an autorun menu (just like the one for CDs) for your USB drive, too! This is how we made an autorun item for PStart, the portable Start Menu:

- 1 Open Notepad and type in the following text:

```
*[autorun]*
*open=PStart.exe* (This is the application that you want to run through the autorun menu)
*action=Open your Start Menu* (This is a description of the action that will be performed)
*icon=PStart.exe* (This is the icon which will be displayed in the autorun menu)
```
- 2 Save the file as `*autorun.inf*` in the root of your USB drive.
- 3 Now, every time you plug the drive into a PC with Windows XP SP2, you'll get an autorun menu that will include the action you specified in `autorun.inf`.